CONGRESS READIES TO PIVOT

The party's moves to jettison allies and rebuild its own poll machinery expose the competing dynamics in the INDIA bloc, blunting the Opposition challenge and the Congress's place within it

By KAUSHIK DEKA

While the world was busy celebrating Christmas on December 25, Congress treasurer Ajay Maken was holding a press conference in New Delhi. A former Union minister known for his proximity to the Gandhi family, Maken launched into a scathing critique of Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal. Calling the former Delhi chief minister "anti-national", he blamed him for the worsening political and administrative situation in the national capital. "If there's one word for Kejriwal," Maken declared, "it's *Farziwal* (fraud)."

What was left unsaid, and has long been a grouse with local Congressmen, is that AAP's rise came at their expense in Delhi. Maken's criticism extended to the dynamics within



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